

Greek Affiliation and Success in College

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Introduction

When students enter college, they have the choice of whether or not to enter a the Greek community. But what are the possible academic and social advantages to be gained by entering this communities? Dangler and Veed (2005) found that in one large Midwestern university, students that entered the Greek system had larger support systems and more friends than students that chose not to. This can impact a student by preventing feelings of loneliness. Loneliness has been linked to such problems as depression, homelessness and can even contribute to suicidal thoughts or actions (Achenbach, Cacialli, Connors & Inderbitzen-Nolan, 1983). Clearly, loneliness and the poor social support that can lead to it are very important issues to examine.

Also, when in college, having a functioning social support network, which can be obtained by joining the Greek system, can help the student achieve great things. Having friends to support them when they are stressed with work, can help students perform better in academic settings. In one study it was shown that GPA and number of close friends were positively correlated (Iturbide & Padilla-Walker, 1991). This study demonstrated this relationship in high school seniors. While Iturbide and Padilla-Walker's findings are important, they have yet to be demonstrated in a college aged sample. A college sample is more generalizable to adults and therefore this finding could be seen as more applicable to real world settings. The current study seeks to confirm this relationship in a college population.

What these two studies display is that social support networks, such as those gained by joining a Fraternity or Sorority, have many positive effects on number of friends. These findings also point to an increase in success in school and possibly beyond. Together they indicate that joining a Fraternity and/or Sorority can improve success in school. The current study is designed to assess the veracity of such statements. **Research Hypotheses**

Research Hypotheses

- those in the Greek system report more close friends
- Greeks will have higher self-reports of coolness
- there would be a positive correlation between number of close friends and college grades
- Greeks would have higher grades than Independents

Method

Participants

Sixty undergraduates from a large Mid-Eastern University participated in the current study. Twenty-six (43.3%) of these participants were male and 76% were Caucasian. The remaining 24% were made up of 17.6% African American and 5% Asian American with the remaining 1.4% being classified as Other. They had a mean age of 21 years with a range from 20 to 24 years.

Materials

A self report survey that consisted of several questions including age, ethnicity, gender, if they are in a fraternity or sorority, current GPA, and number of close friends was created for this study. The Coolness Scale was also included in the questionnaire. The Coolness Scale has 25 nine point Likert-type items behaviors asking students to identify how similar they are to prototypically cool social behaviors (-4 not like me at all to +4 totally like me). Higher scores indicate the student things they are more cool (Pitt, Jackson & Travolta, 2000).

Procedures

The survey was administered during the orientation meeting held at the beginning of the junior year etiquette class. Each of the sixty students who attended that meeting provided complete data.

Results

Univariate statistics for variables collected on the survey were shown in Table 1. The first hypothesis stated that Greek students would report more close friends than Independent students. Contrary to the hypothesis, there was no significant mean difference on number of close friends between Greek students and Independent students $F(1,58) = 0.083, p = 0.775, Mse = 11.43$. The related hypothesis that Greeks would self-report higher levels of coolness was supported, $F(1,58) = 9.23, p = 0.031, Mse = 7.65$. Table 2 summarizes the data for number of friends and social coolness for Greeks and Independents.

The third hypothesis stated that number of close friends would be positively correlated with GPA. Pearson's correlation between GPA and number of close friends was $r(58) = -0.215, p = 0.099$. This result did not support the research hypothesis that students with a higher number of close friends would have higher GPA's.

The fourth hypothesis stated that more Greek students would have High GPA's than Low GPA's and Non Greek students would be more likely to have Low GPA's than High GPAs. There was a relationship between GPA and Greek affiliation, $\chi^2(1) = 5.07, p = 0.024$. Inspection of Table 3 shows that, as hypothesized, Greek students were more likely to have High GPA's than Low GPA's and Non Greeks were more likely to have Low GPA's than High GPA's.

Table 1.
Summary of Greek Affiliation, GPA, and Number of Close Friends

Variable	Univariate Statistic		
Greek Affiliation	Greek 34 (56.7%)		
	Independent 26 (43.3%)		
GPA	High GPA 27 (45%)		
	Low GPA 33 955%)		
GPA	$M = 3.01$	$SD = 1.07$	$N = 60$
Number of Close Friends	$M = 5.93$	$SD = 3.35$	$N = 60$

Table 2.
Means (and standard deviation) Number of Close Friends and Coolness Self-Reports for Greek (n=34) and Independent (n=26) Students

Affiliation	Independents	Greeks
Number of Close Friends	6.08 (3.21)	5.82 (3.50)
Coolness Self-Reports	-1.82 (1.34)	2.87 (1.28)

Table 3.
Summary of High and Low GPA's for Greeks and Independents

GPA	Greek Affiliation		
	Low	High	Total
Independent	16	10	26
Greek	11	23	34
Total	27	33	60

Discussion

The results from these analyses were provided support for portions of the research hypotheses. The first and second hypotheses were not supported, showing no difference between number of close friends for Greeks and Non Greek and no positive correlation between number of close friends and GPA. However, the last hypothesis was supported showing the Greeks were more likely to have High GPA's than Low and Independents were more likely to have Low GPA's than High GPA's. These findings were very interesting because they had contrary findings to Dangler and Veed (2005). In this study, the Greek students did not report more friends, indicating more social support, which was found in this earlier study. The findings were also contrary to Iturbide and Padilla-Walker (1991), in that no relationship was found between GPA and social support, as represented by number of close friends. The related hypothesis that Greeks would report themselves as more cool was supported.

It was found that Greeks were more likely to have High than Low GPA's and Independents were more likely to have Low than High GPA's. This finding was very interesting because it indirectly supports the previous research by substituting GPA, which was found to be positively correlated with number of close friends, for social support and comparing it for Greeks versus Independents. These results are very helpful when considering entering the Greek system. Results of whether or not joining a house can help you to be successful in college are inconclusive. It appears that just because someone is a member of a House, does not mean that they consider their fellow Greek members to be close friends. It also shows that having close friends might not be enough or even the most effective form of social support in order to boost success in college.

When considering all that was found in this study, there are many aspects that increase our cumulative knowledge about social support. While it was shown in past research that students in the Greek system had reported more close friends than Independents, perhaps there are more factors that influence friends rather than just belonging to the same House. In this population, there was no difference in number of friends for both groups. Family members and significant others might be more influential than friends when considering success.

References

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